▶ WEST BENGAL

ANNAPURNA GIVETH, AND TAKETH AWAY

Women's protests spread across Bengal after flagship welfare scheme sees patchy rollout. Suvendu says he's righting past wrongs

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**



PTI



For Anita Khatun, the Rs 3,000 promise was a lifeline. Its absence, the starkest opposite. On August 22, the 32-year-old was found hanging at her home in Bachahar village in Malda's Gazole. Her family talked of financial distress caused by irregular payments under West Bengal's Annapurna Yojana. Her husband's daily-wage earnings had never sufficed. Anita, they said, was a beneficiary under Lakshmir Bhandar, the flagship scheme of the Trinamool Congress regime. She applied for Annapurna after the change of government, received the allowance once, then allegedly went without payments for two months. She had approached the panchayat and block offices, in vain. The pursuit has ended at the morgue.

There is no official finding that the scheme caused her death. Police pointed to domestic disputes, including a disagreement over filling up the Annapurna form. Yet Anita's death has given a human face to the scheme's controversial rollout, a passage so far measured in crores of applications, rejected forms and delayed bank transfers.

It was one of the BJP's biggest pre-poll welfare promises. Eligible women between 25 and 60 were to get a monthly Rs 3,000 through direct benefit transfer—twice of what they got towards the end under Lakshmir Bhandar. By July 10, an astounding 18 million applications had poured in. Of the 16.2 million initially verified, 14.5 million were found eligible. The third instalment began moving into beneficiaries' accounts on August 17, a total of around Rs 4,350 crore.

TECHNICAL KNOCKOUT

The numbers also reveal the problem—1.7 million applications stand rejected. For a woman who has been told that Rs 3,000 would arrive in her account, the difference between "rejected", "pending verification" and "payment pending" can be difficult to understand. Also, the technicalities. Around one million of the 1.7 million rejections owed to Aadhaar numbers apparently not being linked to bank accounts. Others failed eligibility checks—there was no shortage of those who should not have been applying for dole in the first place. But a poor woman caught in the cobwebs of rules only knows the money has not arrived.

The government has now asked BDOs and banks to organise camps to resolve Aadhaar linkage problems. Wrongly rejected applicants can seek re-verification through the Social Register, with cases to be examined at the district level. The government is also scrupulous about the terms of eligibility: it had to weed out women earning over Rs 10,000 a month, those owning land above a certain threshold, or from families with annual incomes above Rs 12 lakh, not to speak of government employees and income-tax payers. The stricter verification, it says, was necessary precisely because of alleged irregularities in the old system.

Chief minister Suvendu Adhikari claims the scrutiny uncovered dead beneficiaries, people who had moved away, multiple accounts and suchlike.